# Creation as Communion in Contemporary Orthodox Theology

*Aristotle Papanikolaou*

This paper will critically compare the creation theologies of Sergius Bulgakov, Vladimir Lossky, and John Zizioulas. I offer this critical comparison of the three most influential trajectories in contemporary Orthodox theology to discern whether, in fact, contemporary Orthodox theology has anything to offer to the wider, global discussion of Orthodoxy's response to questions and concerns about the environment.

In previous work,[1] I have argued that, their differences notwithstanding, contemporary Orthodox theologians ground their theology in one fundamental principle: the realism of divine-human communion. The realism of divine-human communion affirms that God exists so as to be free, as love, to create and unite Godself with what is other than God—creation. From the point of view of creation, the realism of divine-human communion means that creation exists so as to be in communion with God. Bulgakov's, Lossky's, and Zizioulas's agreement on this fundamental axiom does not necessarily lead to similar conclusions on their theologies of the Trinity, especially on the relation of apophaticism and the importance of the concept of the divine energies to the doctrine of the Trinity. In similar fashion, I will demonstrate that the principle of the realism of divine-human communion shapes the theologies of creation for these theologians, but this shared starting point does not prevent the emergence of fundamental differences in their creation theologies.

## Sergius Bulgakov

The key to understanding Bulgakov's theology of creation is his trinitarian theology, and the key to understanding his trinitarian theology is to deci-

pher, literally, what he means by Sophia, which, in my estimation, has been the chief stumbling block to appreciating Bulgakov's work fully. The question that must be posed to Bulgakov is the following: why is the concept of Sophia necessary for theology?

Sophia, for Bulgakov, is entailed in the logic of the patristic affirmation that the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit are *homoousios*. In both the Latin and Greek forms of trinitarian theology, the *homoousios* was interpreted in terms of the attributes common to the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit and as what constituted the unity of the Godhead. While Bulgakov does not necessarily dispute these understandings of the *homoousios*, they do not fully account for the God-world relation. It is a particular understanding of the God-world relation in terms of communion that leads Bulgakov to claim that a further theological unpacking of the *homoousios* is needed. He states that "the dogma of consubstantiality, which safeguards the unity of the Holy Trinity, thus remains a sealed book so far as we are concerned—for in a religious sense it has been neither assimilated nor unfolded."[2] For Bulgakov, the unfolding of the *homoousios* leads logically to Sophia.

The key to understanding the link between *homoousios* and Sophia in Bulgakov lies in his notion of the self-revelation of God. The relation between the Father and the Son is the self-revelation of the Father in the Son. This self-revelation, however, is only complete in the Holy Spirit, who unites the Father and the Son. Bulgakov identifies the Father as "the transcendent principle within the Holy Trinity . . . the divine subject, the subject which manifests itself in the predicate . . . intelligence contemplating itself, the source of being and love, that love which cannot but diffuse itself,"[3] "Divine Depth and Mystery, the Divine Subject of self-revelation."[4] It seems that Bulgakov is saying that if one were to bracket the self-revelation of God in the Son and in the Spirit, the Father is Absolute Spirit, which cannot even be called God, since the latter is a relative term. This Absolute Spirit is an unknowable, impenetrable mystery. It is in the self-revelation of the Father in the Son that the Father transcends this transcendence, or reveals his transcendence as immanence, and is immanent as revealed.

The Son, thus, is the Image of the Father, the Word of the Father in which is contained all words; the "objective self-revelation"[5] of the Father, the Truth of the Father, and, as such, the divine content. As Bulgakov puts it, "the Son surrenders Himself as the *Word of all and about All* to the Divine world; He serves the self-revealing Divinity, and He posits Himself as the *content* of this self-revelation."[6] Bracketing now the person of the Holy Spirit, the Father knows the Son as the Image of the Father, and the Son knows the Father as that of which he is the perfect image. The relationship is one of mutual

mirroring, but this mirroring is not yet the accomplished self-revelation of God. Such a revelation is not a self-revelation unless it is actualized, and this actualization is accomplished in the person of the Holy Spirit, who is the love that unites Father and the Son: the Father loves all that is revealed in the Son, and the Son returns this love kenotically as the hypostatic image of the Father. As Bulgakov explains, "this dyadic relation of the Father and the Son can in no wise exhaust the self-definition of the Absolute Spirit, however, for it is characterized not only by self-revelation as self-consciousness, as being in truth, but also by self-revelation as self-life, as being in beauty, as the living out of its proper content."[7]

According to Bulgakov, the self-revelation of the Father is not complete until the content that is revealed in the Son is actualized as life by the Holy Spirit. In this sense, the Holy Spirit, for Bulgakov, is the "spirit of truth" and

> relates not to the content, but to the special form and to the divine hypostases in which this content is manifested. . . . In himself he constitutes this transparency, for he is Love. And as such the Holy Spirit represents the principle of the quickening spiritual reality within the Holy Trinity, the reality and the life of the Word of Truth. The reality of Truth is Beauty . . . the Word becomes adorned by beauty, because the Holy Spirit abides in him. The Holy Spirit who abides in the Son, manifests him to the Father in beauty. . . . In the divine self-revelation . . . the Holy Spirit represents the principle of reality. He transforms the world of ideas into a living and real essence.[8]

Insofar as the Holy Spirit is the form of the content revealed in the Son, the Holy Spirit is identified with the glory of God. The Trinity is thus the self-revelation of God to Godself, specifically the self-revelation of the Father mediated through Godself, the revealing hypostases of the Son and the Holy Spirit, the Word and Glory of God, respectively.

Where does Sophia fit into all this? In the end, Sophia is identified with *ousia* in Bulgakov's system. This may sound ordinary, except that Sophia is not simply an attribute possessed by all the persons of the Trinity. Sophia is, quite simply, the *ousia* of God hypostatized in the trihypostatic self-revelation of God, but, as such, it is no longer simply *ousia*. Bracketing the self-revelation of the Father in the Son and the Spirit, Bulgakov argues that the Father remains "in himself undisclosed"; as undisclosed, he adds that

> the divine Sophia abides in the Father primarily as Ousia, the undisclosed depth of his nature . . . his Ousia abides within him, unrevealed, in the capacity of Sophia. This relationship may be expressed by

> the following formula: Sophia so far as the *hypostasis* of the Father is concerned, connotes predominantly Ousia—prior to its own revelation as Sophia.[9]

Only in the self-revelation of God in the Son and the Holy Spirit is all that God *is* revealed; it is only in this self-revelation that all that God is *is*; that is, there is an identification in Bulgakov between the self-revelation of God and the fullness of God's existence. In this fullness of God's existence, *ousia* is no longer an apophatic concept indicative of impenetrable mystery and transcendence of the Absolute; *ousia* is Sophia. Sophia, then, for Bulgakov is God's being as the self-revelation of the Father in the Son and the Holy Spirit. As Bulgakov himself states, "Sophia is Ousia as revealed,"[10] or "Sophia is the revelation of the Son and the Holy Spirit, without separation and without confusion,"[11] or "Divine Sophia is God's *exhaustive* self-revelation, the fullness of divinity, and therefore has absolute content."[12]

At this point, however, it is still not quite clear why the concept of Sophia is necessary for trinitarian theology and, thus, what Bulgakov really means to signify with Sophia. Although Sophia is identified with the *ousia* of God, Bulgakov seems to be arguing that, as hypostatized in the trinitarian relations, *ousia* is no longer what simply signifies the common attributes or what accounts for the unity of God as Trinity. As hypostatized, it is the very being of God as trinitarian self-revelation. As the very being of God it must necessarily, Bulgakov argues, refer to God's relation to the world and not simply to the intratrinitarian relations. Why is this the case? Because, for Bulgakov, the self-revelation of God in the Logos and the Holy Spirit is the revelation of all that God is, and included in all that God *is* is God's relation to creation and humanity. Let me be clear: Bulgakov is not arguing for the eternity of a creation that is restricted by time and space. If, however, all theology is grounded in the premise that God has revealed Godself as Creator and Redeemer, it is impossible for Bulgakov to conceive the thinking of God that does not include God existing as eternally relating to creation in some way. Thus, God's self-revelation as the revelation of all that God *is* is also God's being as love and, thus, as freedom to create and redeem what is not God, and, thus, as eternally relating to creation. For those who would argue that Bulgakov is making creation constitutive of the being of God, Bulgakov explicitly denies this charge. To think the being of God in such a way that brackets creation would be to try to determine God's relation to the world in terms of deliberation and volition, which is incoherent for Bulgakov, especially if God's being is the all in all. For Bulgakov, it is impossible to conceive of God's being as not already existing as an eternal relation to creation, even

if that means that God is not compelled to realize this creation in time and space.

Sophia, then, refers to the being of God as existing as this eternal relation to creation; as the self-revelation of all that God is, which is the God who is from eternity freedom and love toward creation; as the *ousia* hypostatized, which is "more" than simply the unity of God or common attributes but the very being of God and, as such, as God's eternal relation to creation. It is for this reason that Bulgakov argues that

> the *Divine Sophia* is nothing other than *God's nature*, His ousia, not only in the sense of power and depth, but also in the sense of self-revealing content, in the sense of All-unity. . . . Sophia is the Pleroma, the Divine world, existent in God and for God, eternal and uncreated, in which God lives in the Holy Trinity. And in itself this Divine world contains all that the Holy Trinity reveals about itself and in itself; it is the Image of God in God Himself. . . . It is the real and fully realized divine Idea, the idea of all ideas, actualized as Beauty in ideal images of beauty.

Bulgakov then links Sophia with that famous Russian theological term *sobornost*: Sophia is the "cosmic *sobornost* of concrete all-unity in divine love."[13]

As the all-unity, Sophia is also identified with another famous Russian theological term, *bogochelovechestvo*, which is probably untranslatable but has been rendered as God-manhood, the humanity of God, or divine-humanity. The term divine-humanity signifies in a more concrete way that God's being as trinitarian is always already an eternal communion with humanity, and this always already eternal communion with humanity becomes the foundation for God's creation of the *anthropos* as the image of God and of the incarnation of the Logos in Jesus. Creation in time and space is essentially a repetition of the being of God, which includes the self-revelation of the Father in the Son through the Holy Spirit. Bulgakov distinguishes between the divine Sophia and the creaturely Sophia, with the divine Sophia being the foundation for the becoming of the world in time and space. As the soul of the world in time and space, it is the creaturely Sophia, the power of the world in its becoming toward union with the divine Sophia, which is divinization for Bulgakov—the unity of the divine and creaturely Sophia. Divine-humanity is an especially important concept in this scheme for Bulgakov, since it is in and through humanity that the world is divinizable. Even though Sophia is about God's relation to the world, it is identified with divine-humanity for Bulgakov because it is in and through humanity that the world is divinizable. As Bulgakov explains,

> the central point from which sophiology proceeds is that of the relation between *God* and *the world*, or, what is practically the same thing between *God* and *humanity*. In other words we are faced with the question of the meaning and significance of Divine-humanity—not only insofar as it concerns the God-human, the incarnate Logos, but precisely insofar as it applies to the theandric union between God and the whole of the creaturely world, through humanity and in humanity. Within Christianity itself there is a neverending struggle between the two extreme positions of dualism and monism, in a constant search for truth, which can only be found in the synthesis of Divine-humanity. . . . The dogma of Divine-humanity is precisely the main theme of sophiology, which in fact represents nothing but its full dogmatic elucidation.[14]

In essence, what Bulgakov is saying is that if the world, the not-God, is capable of communion with God, then the world is already, in some way, in God, which means that the world is also, in some way, divine. As Bulgakov states, "this is not pantheism, but panentheism," and, in his mind, this is the only way to account for a Christian panentheism.

## Vladimir Lossky

For Lossky, all theology begins with the Incarnation, the realization of divine-human communion in Christ. The Incarnation itself, as the instantiation of divine-human communion, demands that theology be apophatic. Apophaticism for Lossky is not simply defining God in terms of what God is not. The heart of apophaticism is the affirmation of the seemingly contradictory notion of God as simultaneously transcendent and immanent to creation. Apophaticism, in one sense, affirms the transcendence of God—God is Other than creation and exceeds all attempts to express God in language, symbols, or reason. In another sense, however, God's transcendence is such that God is free, a freedom that is realized as love, to unite what is Other than God with Godself. God's transcendence is not simply the affirmation of a cold, distant God but a God who makes Godself available for communion. A theology of creation must be consistent with these fundamental affirmations about God as transcendent and immanent to creation, and if it is to do so, such a theology must be antinomic; that is, it must exceed any simple binary form of human logic and necessarily express two contradictory but equally true affirmations. Apophaticism, then, for Lossky, is theology understood as a lived experience of union with God made possible by

the Incarnation. The very expression of this lived union must be antinomic, that is, can only be expressed in statements that are seemingly contradictory but true. Antinomic expressions disrupt any complacent knowledge of God that grounds itself in human reason, and they keep the theologian, seeking knowledge of God, moving in the right direction through the performance of ascetical practices, which are really the only means for a true knowledge of God as personal union.

The principle of the realism of divine-human communion is what grounds two central concepts for Lossky's theology of creation: creation *ex nihilo* and the essence/energies distinction. Put another way, for Lossky the realism of divine-human communion necessarily leads to these concepts as adequate expressions of a theology of creation. Creation *ex nihilo*, for Lossky, expresses the fact that creation is not necessary and utterly dependent on the freedom and will of God. Creation *ex nihilo*, however, is also required for affirming a created Other that is capable of a non-necessary communion with God. A non-necessary communion with God is one realized in freedom and love, but such a communion is not possible if creation is eternally present with the divine in either a material or ideal form. Lossky's concern with an eternal world is not so much about power but about love; an eternal world or a necessary creation limits, most of all, God's freedom to love, to risk Godself in creation by creating what refuses God's love.

A logical consequence of affirming creation *ex nihilo* is the distinction between the essence and will of God. The essence of God is eternal, while creation itself is a product of God's will by which God relates to creation both in terms of creating and redeeming. The essence/will distinction is a further affirmation that creation itself is not God, is Other than God, is not necessary, and, hence, a result of God's freedom. The essence/will distinction still does not capture all that can be said about a creation that is a result of God's *loving* will. God wills out of love to create what is Other than God, and this created Other exists by virtue of its relation to this loving will of God. Put another way, God creates the created Other in communion and for communion with God. This always already existing participation as communion with God in and through creation is expressed most adequately in the essence/energies distinction, which, for Lossky, finds its most developed and coherent formulation in Dionysius the Areopagite. The essence of God signifies what is Other to creation, utterly transcendent and unknowable; the energies signify the activity of God in and through which the created Other realizes a real communion with the divine without being God, that is, the divine essence.

It is through the essence/energies distinction that Lossky interprets the divine *logoi* or the divine ideas, especially in the work of Dionysius and Maximus the Confessor. The logical consequence of a non-necessary creation based on God's free, loving will is the identification of the "divine ideas" with the energies rather than the essence of God. If the essence/will distinction within God is meant to express the transcendence of God vis-à-vis creation, between the necessary and non-necessary, then the idea of creation must also be a product of God's will. God is bound by no necessity to create, not even the idea to create. The identification of the divine ideas with the will of God is meant to preserve God's freedom to create. Lossky thus rejects any identification of the divine ideas with the divine essence, one that he sees in different ways in both neoscholasticism and Bulgakov's sophiology. To equate the divine ideas with the inner life of God either disparages the created world and deprives it "of its original character as the unconditioned work of the creative Wisdom," or, creation itself is introduced into the inner life of God, thus becoming determinative of God's very being.[15] In the first case, creation loses its uniqueness, its otherness insofar as being derivative of God's essence; in the second place, God's otherness is lost as creation forms part of the very being of God. In both cases, a communion of love and freedom is precluded.

Identified with the divine energies rather than with the divine essence, the divine ideas are not simply static replicas of created realities. Rather than serving as models for replication, the divine ideas intend creation toward a particular end. "The divine ideas are inseparable from the creative intention."[16] This intention of God for creation is communion in God's love. Thus "they no longer constitute a 'hinterworld,' but the very depth of the creature, its method of participation in divine energy, *its vocation to the highest love*."[17] Their purpose is to "determine the different modes according to which created beings participate in the creative energies."[18] Created existence is an image of the divine, but it is an image that participates in the divine. The ideas determine the mode of participation, that is, the degree and extent of participation in the uncreated energies. The different modes of participation are what accounts for the diversity of created existence. As image, a created thing reflects the uncreated light of the energies the more it corresponds to its divine idea, that is, the more it participates in the uncreated energies according to the mode intended by the divine ideas. This understanding of the divine ideas shapes Lossky's understanding of analogy, which he defines as the particular capacity of a created being to participate in God.

Of all the divine names, the one that most encapsulates God's relation to creation is, not surprisingly, love. Love signifies the ekstatic character of

God's relation to creation, insofar as God goes outside of Godself to effect the created Other; love also signifies a God-world relation based on freedom, which makes possible a rejection of God's love but is also the condition for the possibility of a real divine-human communion. Love in the created order is more than an intention to create on God's part; it is *the* divine energy that creates and stirs creation toward its final end, which is love. In a poignant summary written early in his career, Lossky says:

> The two ways in theology correspond to the way of divine love by which God proceeds outside of himself, creating all in order to be manifest in all, and returning all created beings to the divine union by the love that God inspires in them. In this "eternal circle" of divine Love, God appears as Love, proceeding outside of his essence and creating all things by his energies, and as Beloved, remaining united in himself in his procession, in whom no thing can participate even though he is present in all things [*imparticipable même en participations*]. As Love, God gives proportionally his infinity to created beings, in defining their "analogies" (ideas); as Beloved, he produces in created beings the love that is the analogy of the will of beings, making them desire union in the divine energies, according to the pre-established mode for each being.[19]

In God's relation to the created order one discerns in Lossky's thought a type of metaphysics of love. Love is the beginning, middle, and end of creation. The primacy of this name flows naturally from the uncreated/created distinction; only the love of God can create an "other" outside Godself, which is created being. It is also the soteriological principle of union that constitutes love as the metaphysical principle of creation.[20] Knowledge cannot bridge the gap between the created and the uncreated. Mind, in that it is created, cannot transcend the created. Union requires a leap beyond the created toward the uncreated. In that God's love is ecstatic in going forth from Godself to create an other, this very ecstatic love is at work in creation, allowing creation to transcend its own limits, even those of mind, in order to unite with the uncreated. This ecstatic love of God is the very life source of all creation and the gift that grants to creation the capacity for its own ecstatic love toward God.[21]

The revelation of Christ reveals that God is both transcendent and immanent to the world. God is *hyper*essence, nonbeing, ontologically other than creation, but immanent through God's uncreated energies. God is most present in creation through God's love, which is the beginning, middle, and end of created existence. Thus, in relation to creation the Incarnation reveals

a God who is nonbeing, essence and energies, essence and will. It reveals more, however, in declaring God to be Trinity.[22]

## John Zizioulas

Zizioulas's starting point is also the realism of divine-human communion, but the revelation of this communion is not so much the fact of the Incarnation as much as the early Christian experience of the Eucharist, even if the experience of the divine in the Eucharist is itself grounded in the life of Christ.

Like Lossky, Zizioulas affirms that the principle of the realism of divine-human communion demands the affirmation that God created *ex nihilo*. This assertion, for Zizioulas, constitutes the first leavening of Greek cosmology by the Fathers of the Church en route to an articulation of a trinitarian theology of personhood. Also like Lossky, the affirmation of creation *ex nihilo* is less about asserting God's transcendence or absolute freedom and more about the conditions necessary for a real communion with the divine. For Zizioulas, communion implies difference; communion is the overcoming of division for the sake of difference. For there to be a communion between the uncreated and the created based on freedom and love, then the created must be "Other" to the Uncreated, with its own integrity. Creation *ex nihilo* is the only way in which creation itself can exist in such a way so as to be capable for communion with the noncreated, with what is "Other" to creation, that is, God. This is the way to make sense of the following remark by Zizioulas:

> Now it is all too easy to admit *on a doctrinal level* that for Christians things are different because the world was created *ex nihilo*. But I venture to suggest that unless we admit *on a philosophical level* that personhood is not secondary to being, that the mode of existence of being is not secondary to its "substance" but *itself primary* and constitutive of it, it is impossible to make sense of the doctrine of creation *ex nihilo*.[23]

For Zizioulas, divine-human communion is a realization of personhood, and the precondition for personhood is creation *ex nihilo*.

There is a negative consequence, however, to creation *ex nihilo*, one that is absent in both Bulgakov and Lossky and that explains what Zizioulas means by admitting "on a philosophical level that personhood is not secondary to being." Creation as created *ex nihilo* is inherently marked by finitude, which means for Zizioulas that it is inherently marked by death. In itself, creation is surrounded by nothing and tends toward annihilation of itself, which is

death. There are glimmers of striving to transcend these limitations in an effort to realize a personal, irreplaceable, eternal uniqueness, which is how Zizioulas defines personhood, but in the end, all these attempts are ultimately tragic insofar as death is inherent to finite existence. As Zizioulas states: "If we take the world as a 'whole,' as an entity in itself, which we *can* do if we regard it, as we do, as *finite* and as *other* than God. . . . All this means that creation *taken in itself* . . . constitutes an entity surrounded and conditioned by *nothing*: It came from nothing and will return to nothing."[24] The idea of creation in itself "surrounded and conditioned by nothing" plays a very central role in Zizioulas's theological system. In terms of his trinitarian theology, one cannot fully understand his controversial claims about the monarchy of the Father without going back to the concept of creation *ex nihilo*. If creation itself is surrounded by nothing, then its longing for freedom from the limitations of its own nature can only be secured through a communion with what is not created, that is, the divine. But if freedom is defined for created being as a freedom from the limitations and necessity of nature, by what Zizioulas calls the "given," and if this freedom is realized through a communion with the divine, then God's very existence must also be such so as not to be bound by necessity. The monarchy of the Father, for Zizioulas, is meant to express the theological claim that God is not bound by the necessity of essence but freely constitutes the divine being as trinitarian. This form of freedom within the divine life is necessary for created being if it is to have any hope to free itself from the necessity of death inherent in created existence. The basic axiom for Zizioulas is that God cannot give what God does not have, and if God is bound by the necessities of God's essence, if God is to be strictly identified with God's essence, then so must created existence: both are bound by the "given." So, philosophically, the priority of a relational ontology is indicated by the longing for freedom from the *nothing* that surrounds created existence that is realized in communion with what is other than created existence; theologically, this human longing for communion with the divine, a communion that overcomes the division between the created and the uncreated for the sake of difference, that is, personal uniqueness, is only possible if God exists in such a way so as to be free to be in communion with what is not God; in other words, God must exist as a trinity of persons whose communion is grounded in the monarchy of the Father.

For Zizioulas, this longing for personal uniqueness through communion is accomplished in the *hypostasis* of Christ. Being persons is an event of union in the *hypostasis* of Christ. To exist in the *hypostasis* of Christ is to share in the eternal relation that the Son has with the Father. It is to be constituted as a

unique, irreplaceable being through a relation of love and freedom that exists in the Father-Son relation; it is a freedom from the annihilation that surrounds created existence.

This personal uniqueness is not limited to human beings but is possible for all created things, though human beings function as the mediators of this personal uniqueness to all created things. Human beings, according to Zizioulas, have the capacity to function as priests of creation, whereby they bring all of creation into relation to God in the person of Jesus Christ and in so doing render all created things as unique and irreplaceable.

## Toward a Trinitarian Theology of Creation

One of the most interesting points of comparison between Bulgakov, Lossky, and Zizioulas is their understanding of the principle of *creation ex nihilo*. Lossky and Zizioulas share the claim that the Christian understanding of creation *ex nihilo* is not strictly about securing God's transcendence or absolute freedom; it is also the necessary precondition for a communion of love and freedom between the uncreated and the created. This communion is not made available simply to human beings but to all created realities as mediated through human beings. Communion, for both theologians, consists of relations based on difference, but it is a difference that does not degenerate into division but that constitutes that difference as particularity, uniqueness, and irreducibility, that is, as "Other," in and through freedom realized as love. Bulgakov does not deny *creation ex nihilo* but clearly understands it in a way different from Lossky and Zizioulas. Although he is often misunderstood as positing a Platonic form of eternal creation, such is not the case. Bulgakov is arguing that if the Trinity-as-Sophia is the self-revelation of God to Godself, then it is impossible from our standpoint to think how that self-revelation does not entail all that God is in relation to creation. This "all that God is in relation to creation" is eternal; thus, there is an eternal aspect to creation. There is something else at stake in this discussion for Bulgakov: if theology does not admit this relation of creation to God's trinitarian being, then there is no way, according to Bulgakov, to account for how the not-God can be in communion with God. Creation itself must contain a divine principle, Sophia, if it is to have any hope of union with the uncreated. On this point, Zizioulas and Bulgakov appear to be on opposite sides of the fence, with Zizioulas affirming an understanding of creation surrounded by nothingness and Bulgakov emphasizing the divine principle in creation. For Bulgakov, the mediating principle between God and creation is Sophia; for Zizioulas, it is the *hypostasis* of the Logos. Lossky stands somewhere in between

in identifying this mediating principle with the uncreated divine energies, which are always present throughout creation and which realize the divine ideas, the latter of which, however, are created and not eternal.

These theologians also agree that created realities are personalized in communion with the divine. They do not, however, talk about that communion in the same way, and it is in the way they talk about communion that we can discern the more substantial differences between their theologies, differences that have implications for an Orthodox theology of creation. For Lossky, each created reality participates in the divine according to the degree and mode determined by the divine ideas, which are identified with the divine energies. Lossky would add that the degree and mode of the tree's participation in the divine ultimately depends on how humans relate to the divine. Although for Bulgakov, the point of contact between the divine and the created is Sophia, he shares with Lossky the affirmation that creation is already, in some way, participating in God. The realization of the creaturely Sophia ultimately depends on how humans relate to the divine. In similar fashion, humans function for Zizioulas as priests of creation, personalizing all of creation in offering it to God for communion. Curiously absent from Zizioulas is the centrality of the concept of divine energies for understanding this personalization.[25] Zizioulas argues that the essence/energies distinction is "essentially nothing other than a device created by the Greek Fathers to safeguard the absolute transcendence of God without alienating Him from the world."[26] More recently, Zizioulas has amplified that

> "maximizing" the role of divine energies may obscure the decisive significance of personhood for the God-world relationship—and this is, in fact, the case with many modern Orthodox theologians. It is extremely important not to forget or overlook the fact that the God-world relationship is primarily *hypostatic*, that is, in and through *one person* of the Trinity and not through an aspect of God's being that belongs to all three of the Trinitarian Persons, such as the divine energies.[27]

Although Zizioulas may not reject the essence/energies distinction outright, nowhere in his theological writings does he integrate the distinction into his theology in such a way as to attribute a soteriological significance to the notion of divine energies. The primary soteriological category for Zizioulas is not energies but *hypostasis*, since all of creation is personalized in the *hypostasis* of Christ by being incorporated into the Body of Christ in the Eucharist. One question that this critical comparison raises is whether or not the concept of divine energies is as central to Orthodox theology, and in particular

to an Orthodox theology of creation, as is often assumed. It certainly is not central to Zizioulas's theology, nor to Bulgakov's.

There are, however, some troubling aspects to Zizioulas's creation theology, and these may or may not be related to his rejection of any meaningful soteriological significance to the essence/energies distinction. Zizioulas's creation theology is built upon a series of dualisms: uncreated/created, freedom/necessity, *hypostasis*/nature.[28] This compels him to talk about creation in such a way that creation seems to hang over an abyss of nothingness. Put another way, there seems to be a chasm between creation and the Creator. The impression is that the two are so ontologically distinct that, once created, creation appears to be devoid of divine presence. Zizioulas's theological system and, as we saw, even his trinitarian theology seem to rely on an emphasis, perhaps an overemphasis, on the logic of finitude, by which the createdness of creation is contrasted with God's eternal being. If God's being is what is eternal, then creation is finite, corrupt, and surrounded by death. This set of dualisms tends to forget that creation is indeed the creation of *God*; that is, it is God's creation. As such, there is not a clear sense in Zizioulas on how creation as God's creation is always already relating and participating in God's life, even when annihilation of creation is a possibility. It is one thing to say that annihilation is possible for creation and quite another to say that creation is surrounded by nothing; the latter implies that creation, once created, is completely devoid of God's presence, a position that is dangerously close to nominalism, in spite of Zizioulas's own intentions.

To be fair to Zizioulas, he is not a nominalist, since the uncreated-created divide is bridgeable hypostatically in Christ. He also will make claims that disavow any notion that creation is completely devoid of God's presence: "'Energy,' by being *uncreated*, involves in history and creation the very being of God. . . . For 'energy,' that is God's love towards creation, stems from his very being and is not to be dissociated from it."[29] But these statements come into tension with the rigid set of dualisms upon which his theology of personhood and his trinitarian theology is grounded. If the God-world relation is understood hypostatically for Zizioulas, but if Zizioulas also allows for an understanding of God as creator in terms of the divine energies, it is not at all clear how it all comes together in a coherent manner for him. Perhaps Zizioulas can learn something from Lossky and Bulgakov, who with the concepts of divine energies or Sophia avoid any rigid set of dualisms, so much so that their own tendency is opposite of Zizioulas, with Bulgakov endorsing an eternal aspect to creation and Lossky appearing to affirm the notion of the *apokatastasis*, or the idea that all creation in the end will be saved: "But though creation is contingent in its origin and began to exist, it will never

cease to be; death and destruction will not involve a return to non-being, for 'the word of the Lord endureth forever' (1 Pet. 1, 25), and the divine will is unchangeable."[30]

One of Zizioulas's greatest contributions to theology, one he in part owes to Lossky, is the recovery of the soteriological and existential significance of the trinitarian category of *hypostasis*. *Hypostasis* cannot simply mean that which differentiates the persons of the Trinity; the *hypostasis* of Christ is that in and through which we are saved, in and through we are brought into communion with the divine. Theology needs, however, a more positive understanding of created nature if it is to coherently talk about God's creation and salvation of the world. I think the real challenge for Orthodox theology in the future is to bring Bulgakov, Lossky, and Zizioulas together into a synthesis, meaning to find a way to relate coherently Zizioulas's own trinitarian theology of personhood with the traditional Orthodox distinction between essence and energies, together with Bulgakov's concept of Sophia. Such a synthesis, I think, would be especially fruitful for an Orthodox theology of creation.